The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

America rescued the **missing airman** who had ejected from a fighter jet shot down by **Iran** on Friday. Donald Trump described the mission as “the most daring” in American history. The president said dozens of aircraft were sent to Iran and no one was killed in the rescue. Earlier Mr Trump gave Iran 48 hours to make a deal or open the Strait of Hormuz, otherwise it would face “all hell”.

Iran has yet to respond to America’s rescue mission. A senior Iranian military leader warned America and Israel earlier that “the gates of hell would be opened” should they attack his country’s **energy infrastructure**. On Saturday Iran launched a wave of strikes at targets in the region. **Kuwait** said Iranian drones had struck two power and water-desalination plants, causing “significant damage”. No casualties were reported.

European policymakers are privately pushing back against new **windfall taxes** on big oil, labelling the measures as premature, a source close to the negotiations told *The Economist*. The finance ministers of **Austria**, **Germany**, **Italy**, **Portugal** and **Spain** called for windfall taxes on oil firms amid an energy shock triggered by the war in Iran. In a letter they urged for “those who profit from the consequences of war” to “do their part”. The European

Commission is working on “targeted policy measures”, a spokesperson said.

Iran’s foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, warned that “Radioactive fallout will end life” in the Gulf, after a fourth attack on the area surrounding Iran’s only operational **nuclear power plant** in Bushehr. The plant remained operational following the strikes, which killed one person, Iran’s Atomic Energy Organisation said. Neither America nor Israel has acknowledged the strike.

The Trump administration said it would ask for a significant rise in **defence spending** in its **budget request** to Congress for fiscal 2027. The request includes $1.5trn in military funding, a rise of more than 40% compared with the previous year. The administration said it would partly offset the increase with cuts of $73bn to non-military spending.

Two **wildfires** that ignited on Friday in southern **California** grew rapidly, prompting evacuation orders. At least two helicopters, 36 fire engines and 260 responders are tackling the blaze. Authorities said windy conditions had contributed to the rapid spread of the fires, which have a combined footprint of around 4,521 acres, more than five times the size of Central Park in New York City.

NASA released images of Earth taken by **astronauts** on board the Orion spacecraft that will fly around the **Moon** as part of the Artemis II mission. The craft is now closer to the Moon than it is to Earth; it is on track to arrive early next week. This crew is the first to leave Earth’s orbit since 1972.

Word of the week: “workslop”, the unnecessary AI-generated slop that is produced when bosses tell employees they must use the technology. Read Ethan Mollick’s guest essay on why employers should treat AI as what it is: weird.

Photograph: Getty Images

A symbolic decision for OPEC

Sunday's monthly meeting of representatives from the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and its allies, who are collectively responsible for 40% of all oil output, will be closely watched. With the Strait of Hormuz largely closed, 15% of the world's oil cannot reach its customers. OPEC's decision in March to boost output by 206,000 barrels per day, equivalent to about 0.2% of global supply, was barely a drop in the bucket. The oil shock is intensifying alongside the conflict. On Friday Iran struck one of Kuwait's largest refineries, normally capable of producing 346,000 barrels a day.

OPEC is thought to be considering making at least the same increase again. But because many of the group's members are in the Gulf, many extra barrels from them will remain stuck. Until the strait is passable, any additional production will only really exist on paper.

Photograph: EPA

The American pontiff’s first Easter

Pope Leo will celebrate Easter mass on Sunday for the first time as leader of the world’s 1.4bn baptised Roman Catholics. After a low-profile start to his pontificate, the first American pope has become more outright in his condemnation of some of the Trump administration’s policies. Last month Pete Hegseth, America’s war secretary, called for “overwhelming violence” against “those who deserve no mercy” during a religious service at the Pentagon. A few days later on Palm Sunday, in apparent reply, Leo declared that God “does not listen to the prayers of those who wage war”.

In church politics the 70-year-old pontiff has moved cautiously. Beyond filling the job he vacated, Leo has made only one high-level Vatican appointment. And in words and gestures he has tried to appease the sensibilities of Catholic traditionalists without discarding the liberal approach of his predecessor, Francis, to such issues as immigration, climate and poverty. It is a delicate balancing act.

Photograph: AFP

Beating high egg prices

The price of eggs has fallen by around 60% in America since this time last year, when a dozen cost a record $6.23 on average. This will be a relief for Americans celebrating Easter with cakes, dyed eggs and other eggstravagances. An outbreak of avian flu has wiped out hundreds of millions of chickens in both America and Europe since 2022, squeezing egg supplies. To beat henflation, the Trump administration imported over 650% more eggs last year than the year before—many from Turkey (the country) and Brazil.

While the virus continues to rage, global flocks are slowly recovering. But the egg business is sensitive to the cost of electricity, needed to light barns, and grain, used for chicken feed. Prices in Europe remain high, and the war in Iran may batter the industry. This week an egg in the Netherlands cost a record €0.35 ($0.41)—bad news for those hoping to gorge on *Paashaasjes*, a bready bunny-shaped treat, this weekend.

Photograph: Getty Images

AI comes for the arts

Does it matter if artists use AI? Bob Dylan, an American songwriter and Nobel literature laureate, has started publishing short stories, audio essays and fictional letters by historical figures on Patreon, a subscription platform. Mr Dylan has not commented beyond some cryptic posts on social media. But his fans are getting stirred up because some of the audio recordings seem to have been generated by AI.

Bots are not talented artists, but they are not necessarily worse than humans. “Shy Girl”, a buzzy horror novel, was recently withdrawn by its publisher before its American release after vigilante readers with bot-busting software detected signs of machine involvement. (Mia Ballard, the author, denies using AI.) Lots of the prose was derivative, but some of it was good, and many readers enjoyed it. Expect plenty more such controversies. As a younger Mr Dylan wrote (himself): “You don’t need a weatherman, to know which way the wind blows.”

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Nancy Dixon, Kansas City, Missouri, America
Iskriyana Vasileva, Berlin, Germany
Dervla Batt, Dublin, Ireland

They gave the correct answers of John Stennis, George H.W. Bush, Harry Truman, Chester Nimitz and Gerald Ford. The theme is that they all have current US aircraft carriers named after them.

The questions were

Monday: Richard Nixon proposed which long-running Mississippi Senator, who suffered from poor hearing, as an intermediary who should listen to the Watergate tapes and summarise them for investigators?

Tuesday: Who served as both America's ambassador to the United Nations and director of the CIA in the 1970s?

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

Friday: Which American president pardoned Richard Nixon?

Hell is truth seen too late.

Thomas Hobbes